



Combat Velocity

By Matt Sernett

Illustration by Eric Belisle

Combat can be one of the most fun parts of the DUNGEONS & DRAGONS® game, but it can also take a long time. You might have a blast with an hour-long battle or exult in four hours of epic mayhem, but sometimes a fight can drag out longer than you would like.

For instance, I run a lunchtime session each week, and with a little less than an hour to play each Thursday, most fights bridge two sessions. This situation can present a challenge when we miss a week's play and our memories are foggy about who was doing what, where, and why. Over the past few months, we've been experimenting with ways to pick up the pace so we can cover more ground and play through the adventure quicker. I've found one strategy that works for my game; what works for you will depend upon your group and how much time you have to play. You might find that your game benefits from more than one of the ideas below.

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Roleplay

The simplest and perhaps best way to speed combat is through roleplaying. Not every monster needs to fight to its last breath. Monsters can run away, surrender, make peace, or try to cut a deal. Villains can even turn into allies.

Time Saved: It's up to you. Monsters might fight until bloodied, or until they are outnumbered. They might assess the odds and make a deal when an event doesn't go their way.

Pros: This strategy introduces more roleplaying, and if your group prefers that to combat, it's a win-win situation.

Cons: If you haven't been playing this way, your players might not know how to handle it. Can they trust the orcs to keep their word about leaving the forest? What do they do with the necromancer now that he's surrendered?

The other problem you'll encounter is that you can't betray the players too often in a game where they are used to accepting the surrender of their foes. When enemies escape capture, break their word, or turn on the characters too often, the players won't trust you anymore. Sure, their characters shouldn't doubt the word of the leader of the bandits because the goblins lied to them two weeks earlier, but the players will doubt your sincerity. When that happens, it often results in the characters executing captured enemies, and that can be uncomfortably grisly for the players.

Double Character Damage

This is the strategy that works best for my lunchtime game. All character damage is doubled, including critical hits and ongoing damage, and no other changes are made to the rules.

Time Saved: It doesn't cut combat length in half, but it comes closer than other options.

Pros: The players feel their characters are powerful.

This option has the crucial advantage of being simple. It's easy and fun for players, and because the players do all the work, the DM doesn't need to change anything.

Cons: The monsters have fewer rounds to act and might therefore not be able to show off all their tricks if they have a lot of powers. Also, the players might not feel their characters are threatened because the monsters have less time to deal damage, and the strategies to make the characters feel more threatened (using more brutes, adding more monsters, using higher level monsters, and so on) inevitably lengthen the time spent in combat.

In addition, some players might now have an incentive to pick powers that deal more damage rather than an interesting special effect. If a monster is only going to last two or three rounds, why take the power that immobilizes it when you can take the one that will take the monster out of the picture twice as fast?

Double Everyone's Damage

This might appear similar to the same strategy as halving hit points, and you would think it would have the same effect, but this approach is a bit easier. Doubling a result is simpler than halving a bunch of numbers on a character sheet and as well as die rolls.

Time Saved: Fights feel about 25 percent faster than normal.

Pros: The math is easy for everyone, and you don't need to do any of it ahead of time. Combat is tense for players in a way that doesn't occur with the halving hit point strategy: High damage numbers pose a real existential threat to the characters.

Cons: Even though you might expect the net effect to be the same as for halving hit points, the deadlier nature of combat was more palpable with this method. When the monsters concentrated attacks, a character could go down early and stay down for most of the fight. One of the surprising drawbacks was how dangerous ongoing damage became. Ongoing damage can easily kill an unconscious low-level character with a couple rounds of failed saving throws.

In addition, the players and DM were doing more math. Even though it might not be difficult to double a number, it does lengthen each player's turn, and that adds up.

Average Damage

I've sat in on many playtests and timed player's turns, and in doing this I discovered a surprising time sink: rolling damage. It might be fun to roll 6d6 + 16 damage, but the act of selecting the dice, rolling them, tracking the dice on the table, adding up the

numbers, consulting a sheet for the bonus, and creating a total can add significant time to your turn. You might be thinking that you don't roll that many dice and that you're a math whiz, so it won't take you long. Even so, it does add a number of seconds to your turn. If you want to see how long, time yourself and your friends the next time you play (surreptitiously, if people are likely to become self-conscious or competitive about it).

With this technique, the players (and the DM, as much as possible) calculate the average damage for their attacks before the game begins. A hit deals this amount, and a critical hit deals maximum damage plus the average amount for any extra dice of damage stemming from magical or other bonuses.

Time Saved: How much time you save will depend on how slow people were with dice and math beforehand; a saving of 25 percent is easily achievable.

Pros: The time you don't spend rolling damage can really add up.

Cons: The big disadvantage here is you lose the excitement of rolling dice. That can be a huge part of the joy of combat for the players, and it might be something your group can't stand to lose.

Fewer Monsters

You can save time at the table by giving yourself less to do. The easiest way is by using fewer monsters in a fight.

Time Saved: You might shorten battles by 10-20 percent. It depends on how complicated a fight you typically run.

Pros: You have fewer monsters and effects to track each turn.

Cons: To use fewer monsters, you have to accept one of two choices. You can use more elites and solos, which reduces your options for encounter design. Second, you can decrease the amount of XP that the encounters provide and thereby reduce their difficulty. Neither of these is a great option for regular play, but can be good for an occasional battle.

Simple Character Choices

One of the ways the players can speed up a combat is to pare down their options. If the players don't have to keep an eye on a dozen items with active powers or examine their feats for action options, their turns will go by more quickly. In this case, players should avoid items with daily powers and triggered actions, and instead should choose simpler benefits such as feats that are "always on." It also helps to pick powers that have simple rules.

Time Saved: The time you save will depend a lot on how willing or able the players are to embrace this idea. You could save a minute or two on each player's turn, which can add up.

Pros: Having simpler and more obvious options doesn't mean those options are weaker. Characters might not be able to bring about unusual corner-case results, but they will likely achieve consistently good returns on both attacks and defense.

Cons: This strategy obviously limits the players' choices, and that might be a deal-breaker, especially for the type of player that loves to tinker with character building.

Keep it Exciting

If you can't shorten the combat, you can at least keep it interesting. Sure, combat might last three hours, but if the players are on the edges of their seats to the last minute, everyone is happy. One of the simplest ways to keep the excitement level up is to introduce more foes over the course of a battle. You can also do this by putting some enemies out of the easy reach of the characters. Spread out a few minions with ranged attacks around the characters so the creatures can't be wiped out with a single area attack, or put artillery monsters up on a balcony above the battle.

Time Saved: It doesn't matter if everyone's having fun.

Pros: You and your players won't mind how long the combat takes.

Cons: When you design an encounter to be long but interesting, it can be hard to tell when it turns deadly. If you're good at adjusting on the fly, this might not be a problem. On the other hand, even the most well-designed encounter can turn deadly if the characters roll poorly and the DM has a string of critical hits.

About the Author

Matthew Sernett is a writer and game designer for Wizards of the Coast who has worked on both DUNGEONS & DRAGONS® and *Magic: The Gathering*® products. His recent credits include *Monster Vault*™, *Neverwinter*™ Campaign Setting, and *Magic the Gathering: Scars of Mirrodin*™. When he's not making monsters or building worlds, he's watching bad fantasy movies you don't realize exist and shouldn't bother to learn about.